



PART 3: NIGHT OF THE DEAD

This chapter begins shortly after the adventurers find the *Strionic Resonator* in the previous chapter. If the players do not have any intention of locating the artifact, or they still have other intended goals in town, you may choose to start this chapter after the players have had sufficient time to rest, explore Shadowgrange, and restock on supplies.

UNDEAD MENACE

Events are unfolding beyond the scope of the characters' activities: an army of undead are currently on a murderous rampage, laying waste to all the settlements in their way. Shadowgrange is their ultimate target.

THE HORDE'S PURPOSE

The army is a mad project crafted by Siegfried, an alchemist that formerly called Shadowgrange his beloved home.

Siegfried had devoted his life to defending the village from the horrors that stalk Stensia; most of all, the vampires that kidnapped his neighbours for leisurely meals. Together with his like-minded fiancée, Katarina Brunn, they tried to rally the people to fight back and strengthen their defenses. But with Avacyn's disappearance and the protective wards surrounding the village failing, Siegfried became more and more desperate for answers to save his people.

Three years ago, Siegfried finally acquiesced to his cousin, GERALF's, suggestion: he began to study necro-alchemy, the foul art of bestowing life into stitched together corpses to create unholy abominations called skaabs. The alchemist perfected his craft in secret underneath his shop, waiting for the day that he could drive back the vampire threat with his stitched army.

When the Voldaren vampires came, murdered the mayor Ralph and kidnapped Katarina, something inside Siegfried snapped. He vowed revenge not only upon the accursed vampires that killed his beloved, but also the cowardly villagers that stood idly as it all happened.

The alchemist fled from his home and traveled north to the abandoned Mauer Estate, where he's been working tirelessly to make his dreams of vengeance a reality.

To defeat his hated vampire foes, Siegfried needs bodies. Lots of them. To this end, the alchemist has teamed up with a young necromancer named Rinelda Smitt. Together, they've raised a zombie horde to ravage the countryside. Rinelda leads the horde, destroying all settlements in her way and sending the corpses of her victims back to Mauer Estate, where Siegfried uses them to construct abominations to challenge the Voldaren vampires. In his twisted mind, the alchemist believes this a fitting end for his fellow countrymen, as their cowardly betrayal in life will be redeemed when they serve him in death.

REFUGEES

Word quickly spreads in Shadowgrange that a large group of refugees have arrived from a neighbouring settlement. A group of cathars meets them at the village gate and escorts them to the marketplace, where priests from the chapel (including Flora) arrive to help treat the wounded. Cathars and curious villagers alike crowd around the refugees to find out what happened.

The refugees hail from Mordov, a settlement one day north of Shadowgrange. Yesterday, Mordov was attacked by an army of walking dead – these twenty-six refugees are the only ones that managed to escape. The refugees distanced themselves from the zombie horde with their three carriages and horses.

If the characters interview the survivors and voice any of the following statements or questions, the refugees respond as indicated:

- *What happened?* A fog rolled in from the farbog north of Mordov. It was thicker than usual and carried a stiff chill. Many in town knew it to be a bad omen. They were right. Next we heard the screams. The restless dead were upon us. The shambling remains of folk like you and me attacked the living, biting, tearing... Avacyn protect us!
- *How'd you escape?* Us few that survived were the lucky ones standing near the stables when the undead attacked. We took any horses still there, along with the carriages, and rounded up as many folk as we could. Then we made a blind ride out into the fog. Many of us didn't make it...
- *What attacked your village?* The walking dead. Corpses that should be in the ground, peaceful in the Blessed Sleep. They shambled towards us with pitiless eyes. All they wanted to do was tear us apart. Cared for

nothing else.

- *How many are there?* It was impossible to tell when the attack happened. One moment a fog rolled in, the next they were everywhere. But we saw them again across the valley as we fled. Hundreds of them, definitely.
- *Where did they come from?* When we saw them, they already were all around us. But all the walking dead had dried mud up to their waists. You get muddy like that from walking through the farbog (swamp) north of Mordov, so I reckon that's where they came from.
- *Was it just zombies?* No. It was mostly undead villagers, but I caught a glimpse of two hulking monstrosities lumbering about. They were twice my height and had the strength of ten men – in fact, judging by the number of arms sticking out of the creatures, they very well could've been made of ten men! The abominations were smashing down doors and swatting away cathars like flies. But the worst thing I saw was a human walking amongst these brutes. A teenaged girl chanting and waving a symbol around – I don't know what it was. She was laughing and prancing around as we were being slaughtered left and right. Laughing! It must've been one of those vile necromancers that command the dead. How could something so young be so wicked?
- *Did you see Siegfried?* A man by that name came through our village a few months ago. He was in a foul mood and avoided small talk. He rested, stocked up on supplies, and then headed into the farbog to the north, despite us telling him it was a suicide mission. Never heard anything of him since then.

DEVELOPMENTS

The refugees have more dire news for the crowd around them: as they fled, the survivors saw brief glimpses of the horde beginning to move south, in the direction of Shadowgrange. At the rate they were moving, they'd reach this village in two days.

Panic ensues when this information is revealed. Stensians are stoic folk and dealing with horrors is a grim fact of life, but an entire horde of undead bent on their annihilation isn't something they've ever had to face before. The cathars do their best to maintain order amongst the crowd.

Once she hears about the impending attack, priestess Flora seeks out the adventurers. A meeting of the village leaders is to be called immediately and she asks for the characters to join them.



ART BY SVETLIN VELINOV

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Captain Levi stands ready to defend Shadowgrange and its people.

ILL TIDINGS

With rumors of an undead horde approaching, the leaders of Shadowgrange call a council meeting to determine what should be done. As the most capable adventurers in town, the PCs are invited.

Priestess Flora summons the adventurers to the town hall at the Visgaud Grounds, where Eckhardt Sheckt (proprietor of the Silver Rose Inn and retired cathar) and Captain Levi (leader of the village militia) are waiting.

You are all gathered in the town hall. Here with you are Eckhardt, the owner of Silver Rose inn; and Captain Levi, leader of Shadowgrange's local cathars. Along with Priestess Flora, these people comprise the Town Council.

"Well, you all know why we're here," Flora says without preamble. "If what these refugees say is true, there's a horde of undead rampaging through the countryside and

they'll be here in a matter of days. We must figure out what is to be done."

There are two main options to discuss: defend the town or evacuate.

If they defend the town, Captain Levi has 40 cathars under his command and believes he can conscript an additional 100 townsfolk (hunters, farmers, tradesfolk) of varying combat prowess. Priestess Flora and her ten clergy members can provide divine support to the troops, and she can call up ten trained bowyers (the Moontouched Sisters and others) to fight as well.

If they evacuate, there are smaller settlements south of Shadowgrange within a day's journey. The next biggest settlement is the rancher community called Lammas, two days away. Finally, the greatest military strength nearby is Silbern, a small community built around Silbern Tower. This tower is a lodging and base of operations for a group of cathars called the Silbern Guard, about a hundred

trained fighters. Silbern is three days away to the east.

These are the two options that the council members will argue for, but the characters can come up with different ideas as well.

This is a chance for the players to throw in their own advice about how Shadowgrange should meet the threat. The council members have their own opinions.

Eckhardt: Grim. A seasoned ex-cathar himself, Eckhardt has his doubts that the village walls can hold, and once they're breached, the zombies would easily overrun the village. He advocates evacuation. "We don't have enough cathars to hold off a zombie horde. We need to start evacuating the village and get the people south."

Levi: Also grim, but more optimistic. Levi points out that the roads south are narrow and dangerous. Trying to protect a thousand evacuating villagers would be next to impossible and there will bound to be casualties. He advocates defending the village. "The gates and walls will hold. If the undead cannot breach our defense, their superior numbers will mean nothing."

Flora: Stubborn and fatalistic. Flora sees abandoning the village as an ultimate failure. Countless generations are buried in the village crypt, resting eternally in The Blessed Sleep, and they cannot be forsaken. She advocates fighting to the bitter end if need be. "Our destiny is in Avacy's hands. She would not want us to abandon our ancestors."

This is an encounter best resolved through roleplaying. Let the characters argue their case for whichever response they favor. If you feel they have argued persuasively, their position should carry the day.

Since the characters are probably arguing for a position favored by at least one of the council members, all they really need to do is convince the ones that disagree.

DEVELOPMENTS

Once the council has settled on a decision, they quickly go about relaying orders. If the town is to be defended, skip down to "Defending Shadowgrange." For details to evacuate, go to "Evacuation."

Hours after the council meeting begins, the scouting group led by Silvia confirms that the zombie horde is indeed traveling towards Shadowgrange from the north. It is comprised of about four hundred zombies, three large stitched abominations, two dozen skeletons, and a female human that seems to be herding them. At their pace, the horde should arrive in two days.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 600 XP equally among the characters if the party succeeds in persuading the council to adopt their preferred course of action.

ATTACKING THE HORDE

Bringing the fight to the undead horde would be suicidal. In total, the horde is comprised of 400 zombies, 20 skeletons, 3 skaab goliaths, and a necromancer. The adventurers and any of the townsfolk they'd bring with them would be greatly outnumbered. The only chance of victory in battle is to fight them atop Shadowgrange's walls, where the defenders can utilize their ranged advantage while the horde is kept at bay.

The characters can employ hit-and-run tactics while the horde travels, however. Executed properly, it can whittle away their numbers before the real engagement at Shadowgrange. But make sure to emphasize the sheer magnitude of undead moving together, so the characters are well aware that attacking head-on would be incredibly foolish and lethal.

Adventurers leaving immediately northward can easily find the advancing horde within a day's journey (the horde moves slowly as a group, moving at half the speed of traveling adventurers). Riding horses will shave off a few more hours of travel time.

The horde moves as a loosely organized group herded in the right direction by Rinelda Smitt, a necromancer that stays in the center of the group. Five large wooden wagons are pulled along with the horde by zombies, which are used to collect corpses to send back to Mauer Estate.

This horde isn't so much an "army" as an abnormally large group of undead wandering in the same direction. They do not have formations or follow complex tactics. Any undead that spots the adventurers will instinctively attack. If they lose sight of the adventurers, or if they stray too far from the herd, they head back.

Attacking outlying zombies causes some of the closest undead to take notice. If they spot the assailants, the zombies shamle forward to attack. This triggers a domino effect as more and more undead notice what's going on and join the battle.

The horde comes in waves, with the first wave representing outlier zombies furthest from the horde's center and moves to involve higher concentrations of undead more central to the horde until you get to the fifth wave, the center of the horde where Rinelda resides. The necromancer is nearly impossible to spot in the crowd. When a wave joins the battle, the following wave joins 1d6+2 rounds after.